



VIPUL SHAH

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Duck that Spam

In the last 12 weeks, every tech or non-tech publication contained at least one news item or article about spam, saying how bad it is, how the George Bush government will stop it by passing laws against it, and so on.

Let's face it! Spam is not going away no matter how many laws you pass against it. Stopping spam is far more difficult than carpet bombing a few countries. It costs almost nothing to send a million e-mails, and is enormously profitable—even if only 10 people respond, and buy a University Diploma, a weight loss product, or accept money from the wife of an ex-president of some African country. Until people on the Internet become more alert and savvy, spam is going to be major business, and also a major nuisance.

Most spam e-mails originate from China and some Eastern bloc countries. So, even if spam is outlawed in one country, your mailbox will still overflow with spam originating from other countries. The rate at which spam is increasing, one or two sender countries dropping out won't change the scene much.

Now, since we can't stop spam, we can at least try to duck it. There are few ways to do this. One very popular, but not very effective way, is to use anti-spam software such as Mail-washer. This software is free, and very good at detecting spam in your mailbox. It deletes spam before you download any e-mails and bounces all spam back to the sender in order to appear as an invalid address, and hope that the spammers will remove your address from their list. If your e-mail ID is not critical, you can just create new e-mail accounts every few months, abandon the old accounts and inform every one of the change.

I have started a strategy where if I can't completely stop spam, I can at least reduce it to manageable level. The older your e-mail address, the more important it is to you, and the more spam it attracts. So if you are someone who needs e-mail for your work, then you should allocate some money every year for e-mail—just as you do for mobile phones, faxes or ISP charges. You should sign up for a domain name, which now costs as low as \$7 to \$13 a year and buy e-mail hosting—20 MB or more—as it's not expensive. Usually the hosting company will create a master account

for you, and you can create multiple POP3 accounts or aliases for as little as Rs 300 to Rs 1,300 a year. If you don't want to create multiple POP3 accounts, create just one main account. It can be called **ab@yourdomain.com**. Don't give this address to anyone. Now create few aliases; How many depends solely on how many different categories you can sort your incoming mail into—for example, create a **yourfirstname@yourdomain.com** for all your personal contacts. Ask your friends to never submit this e-mail address to any Web sites which may offer them goodies in exchange for a friend's e-mail address.

Then create an alias—**bank@yourdomain.com** or **abcbank@yourdomain.com**—and use it for banking. Create a separate alias for every e-mail newsletter you subscribe to and so on. In my case, I write for various publications, so I have different aliases such as **digit@vipulshah.com** or **toi@vipulshah.com** for Times of India.

You can even create a **spam@yourdomain.com**, just for those Web sites which insist on your registering with them before you can use their services. Then you won't have to bother checking this e-mail, as it will be full of mailers and offers. Once done, create different folders in your e-mail software and use message rules to route all your incoming mails to the respective folders, depending on the address in the To/Cc field of incoming mails.

Now, you are not at the mercy of spammers. If one of the above aliases receives any spam, you can just disable it by adding it to the 'nobody' list, and all mails to this alias will start bouncing. Also, if you receive spam at **bank@yourdomain.com** you know your bank is leaking, selling or renting your e-mail address to spammers. You may add this address to the 'Nobody' list, and inform the bank that you don't wish to receive communication by e-mail anymore, or even consider taking your business elsewhere.

This strategy keeps your options open and lets you minimise spam, which you can't do with free e-mail addresses. We also know that dot com portals can crash, and thus, so can your free e-mail address. But your own domain name protects you from such uncertainties. 

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